in Telangana two weeks before the election, BJP veteran and former CM B.S. Yediyurappa said Karnataka was "bankrupt", pointing to the six-month extension given to the Seventh Pay Commission (set up to recommend a salary hike for state employees). On November 12, another ex-CM, H.D. Kumaraswamy, whose Janata Dal (Secular) has been inching closer to the BJP, launched a broadside against the guarantees, accusing the Congress of mismanaging things back home while "making tall promises" in poll-bound states. Kumaraswamy alleged that Gruha Lakshmi "had not given a single rupee" to 1 million families and there was a shortage of buses under the Shakti free travel scheme. The CM responded by saying the Opposition couldn't stomach the successful rollout. "Crores of people have benefitted," he said. "The BJP used to make fun of such schemes, but has now included such 'freebies' in the poll manifestos of five states," he added, daring Kumaraswamy to "question this hypocrisy".

Government data shows quick uptake for the schemes. On October 4, L.K. Atheeq, Karnataka's additional chief secretary in charge of finance, had posted on X (formerly Twitter) that 10 million households—62.5 per cent of the roughly 16 million households in Karnataka—were already receiving benefits under Gruha Lakshmi, Anna Bhagya and Gruha Jyothi. Meanwhile, women commuters were averaging 7 million free trips daily on state-run transport buses under the Shakti scheme. Since its launch in June, there has been a 15 per cent increase in overall ridership on government buses.

There is no denying the teething troubles the guarantees are facing. So, if the Rs 2,169 crore payout for Gruha Lakshmi in August covered 97 per cent of the beneficiaries, that coverage dipped to 82 per cent by the next month as enrolment went up to 11.4 million. By early November, DBT transfer to 700,000 bank accounts were pending due to technicalities related to Aadhaar seeding and KYC norms. "We are creating additional log-ins and our anganwadi workers are helping with Aadhaar linking and other issues. In 10-15 days, we will sort out the problems," Laxmi Hebbalkar, the minister for women and child development, said at a press conference on November 8. To meet the rising ridership in state transport, minister Reddy says the state's four transport corporations are now purchasing 5,675 buses. Previous governments had not

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BLANKET COVERAGE?

The guarantees currently reach nearly two-thirds of Kannadiga households

GRUHA JYOTHI

Up to 200 units of free power every month

- **Launched:** August 5
- **Allocation:** ₹9,000 crore
- **Enrolment:** 15.4 mn households

The zero-bill criteria is calculated as the sum of the household's average monthly consumption in the previous fiscal year plus an additional 10 per cent. The state has 21.4 million domestic connections consuming less than 200 units. Total subsidy amount by November was Rs 2,900 crore

GRUHA LAKSHMI

₹2,000 to every woman head of a family

- **Launched:** August 30
- **Allocation:** ₹17,500 crore
- **Enrolment:** 11.6 mn women

India's 'biggest DBT programme' had in three months disbursed Rs 6,600 crore to the districts. Teething troubles exist owing to linking Aadhar to bank accounts and verification process delays. In the first month, 97 per cent of enrolled women received the cash transfer but coverage dipped to 82 per cent in September

THE FUNDS SQUEEZE FOR NEW PROJECTS HAS NOT GONE DOWN WELL WITH MLAs. CM SIDDARAMAIAH HAD TO CONVENE MEETINGS TWICE TO REASSURE HIS LEGISLATORS